The Ripple Effect

A Podcast about the Entangled Work of Pedagogists in Relation with Children, Educators and More-than-human Others

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Introduction

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[Soft background music fades in and continues under the conversation]

Jane: Hello, everyone. This is Jane, and welcome to *The Ripple Effect*, a podcast for early childhood educators who are curious about new ideas shaping early childhood education.

In today's episode, we are going to talk about pedagogists in education. What or who is a pedagogist? If you have never heard of this role before, join me as I discuss this emerging role in Canada with my colleagues, Ilam Muralidharan (hello), Min Jeong Kim (Hi everyone), Cindy Ng (Hello), and Yumeng Sun (Hello). We are educators and graduate students in the Master of Professional Education in Early Childhood Education program at Western University in Ontario, Canada, where we are learning about this necessary role. Why should this role matter to you, to our listeners working in education? We will begin our conversation addressing this very question, and hopefully, as you listen, you will begin to notice the possibilities pedagogists bring to transforming educational spaces. Afterwards, we will move on to discuss some of the ways pedagogists work with educators to create ripples of change in their classrooms. Cindy, can you start us off by speaking to why this role is necessary before we discuss who a pedagogist is?

Cindy: Thanks, Jane. As our listeners know, working in education comes with many challenges. For example, prioritizing outcomes over process, standardized testing, valuing efficiency over curiosity and relationships. Many classrooms have become focused on checking boxes—did the

child achieve X skill by Y age? This has been supported by the concepts of developmental psychology, and it can limit children's opportunities for deep exploration and creative thinking with others.

Jane: But isn't it important to consider children's development with the learning process, or have learning goals? I mean, we all had to learn it throughout the ECE diploma program.

Cindy: We aren't arguing for the elimination of child-development theory, but it is problematic when it becomes the only consideration. A pre-set curriculum tends to prioritize certain kinds of knowledge. This can make it harder for educators to notice and respond to the ideas and questions children bring up that don't align with our pre-established plans. This one-size-fits-all approach overlooks each child's unique interests, perspectives, and curiosity in the classroom.

Ilam: Elaborating on that, because the structure of education we see today has largely been established by ideas stemming from developmental psychology, it effects how we view children, education, and informs teaching practices. It's problematic because it has established a particular way of seeing, of being, of thinking, and this has limited our ability to think differently. What if educators were not considered transmitters of knowledge but co-constructors of meaning with children? A pedagogist can help to shift the focus away from checking off outcomes to composing meaning with others.

Jane: In discussing these concepts, of thinking differently in education, of composing meaning with others, we will be referencing an inquiry project with children, pumpkins, weather, and time that took place in Southwestern Ontario, Canada (see Appendix for mindmap guiding the structure). MinJeong, can you tell us what this project was about? Then we will move on to discuss what working with a pedagogist looks like and how they work with others.

Min Jeong: Sure, the pumpkin inquiry is discussed in the article, *Watching change: attuning to the tempo of decay with pumpkin, weather and young children,* by researchers Sarah M. Hennessy and Tonya Rooney. We chose this project to think with and discuss because it illuminates how pedagogists work with children and educators to disrupt the conventional ways early childhood classrooms engage with pumpkins during the month of October, as Hennessy and Rooney (2021) said, "more than single-use human entertainment" (p. 12). They invite us to sit with the tension of what to do with a noxious, decaying pumpkin, and with the discomfort of not knowing how to move forward, while challenging adult time organized by routine and schedule. This pumpkin–weather–child collaboration de-centres humans, situating them *with* pumpkin, weather, non-human creatures, and with time and space as active participants. It is not about what children can do to pumpkins, but of how pumpkins are already part of the world, interconnected with other worldly relations such as the weather, time and microbes. Pumpkin worlds and children's worlds are not separate but entangled in composing meaning together.

Jane: Yumeng, what was the pedagogist's role in this inquiry?

Yumeng: As Min Jeong mentioned, they created a space for educators to sit with tensions and challenge normalized ways of being. This inquiry disrupted the conventional way of teaching, in which children were no longer at the center of the learning process. It's not about child-led or teacher-directed practices, but about children, educators, and researchers composing meaning with more-than-human others such as the pumpkin, the weather, and non-human creatures. In other words, learning unfolded through the connections between people, materials, and the changing environment. Thinking and constructing knowledge in this way, with the entanglement of relations, caused a ripple effect that disrupted the linear pathways of developmentalism and thinking of only human-centered perspectives.

Jane: Yumeng, you mention thinking with "more-than-human others." For listeners hearing this phrase for the first time, it was coined by ecologist and philosopher David Abram in reference to everything else that is alive and active around us—animals, plants, water, wind, land, insects, weather, and materials. The phrase reminds us that humans are part of the world, not its center. It reminds us that learning happens not just between people, but also through our relationships with environments, materials, and living systems. It invites educators to notice how children are already learning with the world around them, rather than seeing the environment as just a backdrop for activities.

Min Jeong, can you explain how pedagogists work with educators in these kinds of shared inquiries?

Min Jeong: Pedagogists work alongside educators to notice, question, document, and reflect on children's learning, helping create classroom spaces that are dynamic, relational, and responsive rather than rigid and pre-determined. We think with others, and seek knowledge outside of the field of education to explore the possibilities of "what it means to live well together" and create more liveable worlds. We are interested in collaborating, engaging in dialogue, listening attentively, questioning taken-for-granted practice, sitting with discomfort, seeing tensions as generative, and creating openings to invent alternative relational possibilities.

Ilam: Since our work is rooted in these entangled relations, in thinking with the more-than-human, we have to rethink our ideas on what it means to care for others in education. Typically, care in early childhood classrooms involves caregiving tasks such as diapering and monitoring milestones. We want to disrupt this traditional understanding because we see care as a form of resistance - one that invites us to think and see differently.

From this perspective, care is not limited to tending to children's physical needs. Instead, it involves attending to the complex relations that shape educational spaces. Pedagogists draw attention to more-than-human others in order to decenter the human in composing worldly relations. We attend to acts of care by noticing, listening, dwelling, and responding in ethical and situated ways.

Jane: With this broader relational view of care in mind, we can move into the next part of our conversation. We want to explore what this work actually looks like in practice. In particular, how pedagogists cultivate relationships, ask questions, welcome differences, and sometimes stay with tensions rather than rushing to resolve them.

Main Content

Jane: Building on that idea, Yumeng, how do pedagogists cultivate relations?

Yumeng: Cultivating relations with children, families, and the more-than-human requires a certain amount of freedom and less regulation. Freedom to think, to be, and to explore what it might mean to care for and with others in a specific place and time. In education, there is often a lot of pressure on both children and educators that shapes how we coexist, for example, what we are allowed to think, feel, and even what we are expected to "learn." These pressures can become constraining and limiting.

Cindy: With the pumpkin inquiry, we can see how possibilities for care began to open up when the pedagogist and educators let go of control and instead sat with the children to observe the decay. They stayed with the entanglement of relations between the pumpkin, humans, time, and weather. In doing so, they created space for the children to be collectively affected by what was unfolding as the pumpkin decayed—sitting with the children and noticing the reciprocal relations at play, rather than simply facilitating pre-planned activities as we often see in classrooms. This

approach begins to cultivate more worldly relations. Cristina Vintimilla, a scholar and pedagogista, reminds us that when we centre only children's perspectives of an event, we ignore the relational interdependencies between human and non-human others (Vintimilla, 2018).

Jane: Building on this idea of worldly relations, then how is questioning and promoting dialogue lived in classrooms with a pedagogist? What does it mean to question?

Ilam: It means that a pedagogist asks different kinds of questions; they also don't ask questions with already formed answers in mind, nor do they dictate what needs to happen next. The pedagogist, working from a disposition of curiosity and an attunement to what is unfolding, asks questions to promote thinking. Questions act as openings for noticing and wondering, for staying with the unknown or uncertainty. They keep inquiries alive, unfinished.

Jane: So, this sounds like a pedagogist is not an expert but a co-researcher who works alongside educators, children, and families to make meaning together, question taken-for-granted practices, and open new possibilities for thinking and learning?

Cindy: Yeah, but there seems to be a misunderstanding of this pedagogical leadership role in Ontario. For example, the pedagogical team in an organization where I had worked in, they were responsible for providing training to staff, completing monthly visits to check how the rooms are set up, making decisions on the daily routine, whether we had sufficient materials, and how educators should be interacting with the children and how they should facilitate the program. It was a directive role of overseeing and monitoring the operations of the program. Whereas, the *leadership* in the pedagogist role that we are advocating for is a collaborative and non-hierarchical relationship.

Min Jeong: Yes, we see this role as more relational and dialogical, and it de-centers the human. We invite educators to think with questions from multiple perspectives. Using the

pumpkin inquiry as an example, the pedagogist is not asking, "What did the child learn?" Instead, the questions become: How is the pumpkin decaying? How does the weather participate? How does time reshape relations? How do we live with change? The questioning and dialogue unfold among humans, smells, the weather, and invisible microorganisms. Researchers Hennessy and Rooney showed how attuning to decay invited them to notice how the world unfolds in real time. The conversations weren't just between humans; it was between humans and the more-than-human, as these entangled relations shaped one another in interconnected ways.

Yumeng: Thank you, Cindy and MinJeong. I also want to bring up the idea of foreclosures that scholars Cristina Vintimilla and Veronica Pacini-Ketchabaw discuss. Just as we need to attend to openings, we need to be aware of how often foreclosures occur in everyday practice. Foreclosures do not require educators to think or ask questions; they only require them to transmit particular knowledge. For example, learning about pumpkins in the month of October typically involves a predictable set of seasonal activities—reading a pumpkin story, making pumpkin crafts, carving a jack-o'-lantern, and roasting pumpkin seeds. Educators foreclose thought by rushing through pre-planned pumpkin activities instead of lingering or thinking with generative questions.

Yumeng: Questions and dialogue can function as a generative disturbance, playing the role of an agitation that stirs what we have become used to, making space for other possibilities to emerge. This pedagogical friction unsettles what we think is normal or inevitable, keeping inquiries open. It is within this unsettled space that difference can be genuinely welcomed rather than managed or contained.

Jane: Cindy, can you talk to us about welcoming differences?

Cindy: When we say *difference*, we are referring to encounters (with ideas, the human or more-than-human) that often put into question or push against our ideas, values and understandings of education. For example, thinking with care as relational entanglements and not about helping children "catch up" to a standard. It's about resisting narratives that children develop and learn in progressive stages without considering a child's culture, their histories. Thinking with care is far more complex; it's a multi-layered form of inclusion (Land, 2022).

Cindy: Pedagogists see difference and diversity as necessary for meaning-making, not as something to be managed. This means welcoming the invisible, embracing nonlinearity, letting go of control, and making space for difference, including what is "dirty," "smelly," and "messy," like in the pumpkin inquiry. We also see how land and Indigenous teachings of interconnectedness and reciprocity are welcomed in this project, as the researchers think with the story of the three sisters.

Jane: Speaking of which, that's what we will be discussing in our next episode, as it offers a powerful example of these relational ways of living with the land.

Ilam: Yes, we invite educators to think with diverse, multidisciplinary perspectives in building relations with land, their students, materials and the more-than-human. In this way, the researchers and educators resisted timelines and developmental expectations, as watching pumpkin decay introduced different temporal rhythms into the classroom. In conversations where children imagined a monster eating the pumpkin, ecological, temporal, and epistemological diversity emerged as acts of care.

As aspiring pedagogists, we know we are not confined to a box. Neither are educators nor educational practices. We need to move away from practices that normalize differences to make children fit into developmental standards of sameness (Vintimilla & Pacini-Ketchabaw, 2020).

Jane: So welcoming difference, instead of 'managing' or reducing it, what does that mean?

Min Jeong: As we have been saying, our work is relational, thinking with Levinas (1969), a mutual encounter among humans and more-than-human others (as cited in Vintimilla, 2018). When we try to manage difference by removing tension, ambiguity, and conflict, we risk diminishing relationships and closing off differences. That's why thinking with others, with multiple perspectives, is so important. The pedagogist interrupts certainties, what we believe to be true, by staying with the unknown and the discomfort it brings. When our complex work is reduced to what we can simply "do" to pumpkins, we risk flattening relationships.

Jane: As I listen to each of you, and think with Watching Change: Attuning to the Tempo of Decay with Pumpkin, Weather, and Young Children, I'm thinking about moments in my own practice when difference felt uncomfortable—when something didn't fit what I thought learning should look like, and I felt the urge to tidy it up or make sense of it. And now I find myself wondering… what might have happened if I had just stayed with that a little longer.

This project really asks us to slow down—to notice change, decay, the more-than-human— and to let ourselves be affected by them. So maybe a few questions to sit with:

When we encounter a difference, do we try to manage it, or can we stay with it?

Where might our timelines or expectations be closing down other ways of knowing and being?

And what might become possible if we truly welcomed the messy, the uncertainty, and the not-yet-known?

Cindy: By asking these questions, Jane is taking on an important part of reflective practice, taking a critical look at what we have become used to doing. When we think with care from a pedagogist's perspective, we are not trying to simplify complex relations into one-size-fits-all solutions. Care is not about fixing or smoothing things over. Pedagogists support educators in

staying with complexity, chaos, and discomfort rather than eliminating tensions. These tensions are not problems to solve; they are what open up new possibilities and new thinking.

Ilam: This project had many tensions: pungent smells, disrupted plans, impurity, unpredictability, and challenges to classroom norms. For example, decay is dirty, uncertain, uncomfortable, and even unpleasant. But the educators do not rush to clean it up or discard the process. Instead, children were encouraged to stay with the messiness of it all.

We also see tension with routinized practices; for example, the messiness of decaying pumpkin versus the desire for clean, sterile classrooms, and the slow process of decay versus tightly structured program schedules.

Yumeng: There is also tension between educators and pedagogists. Much of this tension comes from misunderstandings about the role itself. From an educator's perspective, a pedagogist may feel like a stranger entering their workspace, someone who is there to judge or critique their work. We understand that this can feel uncomfortable, even threatening. But we see this discomfort as an invitation, an invitation to step into tension together by asking questions and entering into dialogue with one another. The role of a pedagogist is not to remove that tension, but to stay with it and use it as a space for thinking differently.

Conclusion & Implications

Jane: Before we end, we want to briefly gather some of the ideas we've been exploring. Throughout this conversation, we've been thinking about how pedagogists create ripple effects in early childhood education by cultivating relations, inviting dialogue, and staying with tensions and uncertainty in a more-than-human world.

We'll now leave you with a few closing reflections on what this work might mean for educators, children, families, and communities.

Cindy: As we proposed some of these ideas in this podcast, there may be a voice telling you, "this doesn't work for my group", or "we cannot do this at our center or home care." The work of a pedagogist is not to tell educators what to do or what not to do, but we work alongside with educators to think together, like the title of our podcast, *a ripple effect*, we want to gently shift the taken-for-granted ways of doing things in our classrooms and offer a thought of "it is not the *only* way, it doesn't *need* to be".

Yumeng: The pedagogist doesn't fix everything but stays with the "composting" process, letting old assumptions break down to make space for new possibilities. This can feel uncomfortable, but it helps us move beyond habitual thinking. This is why it's important to work with a pedagogist. For ECE educators, this work promotes curiosity, reflection, and ethical engagement, showing that our role involves serious intellectual practice rather than care tasks.

MinJeong: Once you have experienced working alongside a pedagogist, it becomes difficult to return to old ways of practising, because you learn to live with uncertainty, remain with generative tensions, and become more comfortable with discomfort.

Ilam: We invite you to consider and reflect with the following questions: what might we need to unsettle in our own practice to live and learn well together? What kind of humans do we want to raise? And what kind of world do we want to live in? How might we learn to live well with others in a more-than-human world?

Jane: Thank you for joining us for this conversation. I'd especially like to thank my co-speakers for sharing their insights and reflections on the role of the pedagogist, and the relational work of care in early childhood education.

And thank you to everyone listening to this episode of *The Ripple Effect*.

If you have any questions or thoughts you'd like to share, we'd love to hear from you. You can reach us at theripleeffect@gmail.com.

In our next episode, we'll continue this conversation by thinking with the teachings of the Three Sisters and what they might offer to early childhood pedagogy.

Until then, we invite you to notice the small moments of questioning, dialogue, and curiosity in your own practice—because sometimes even the smallest shifts can create a ripple effect.

[Background music swells, plays for a few seconds, then fades out]

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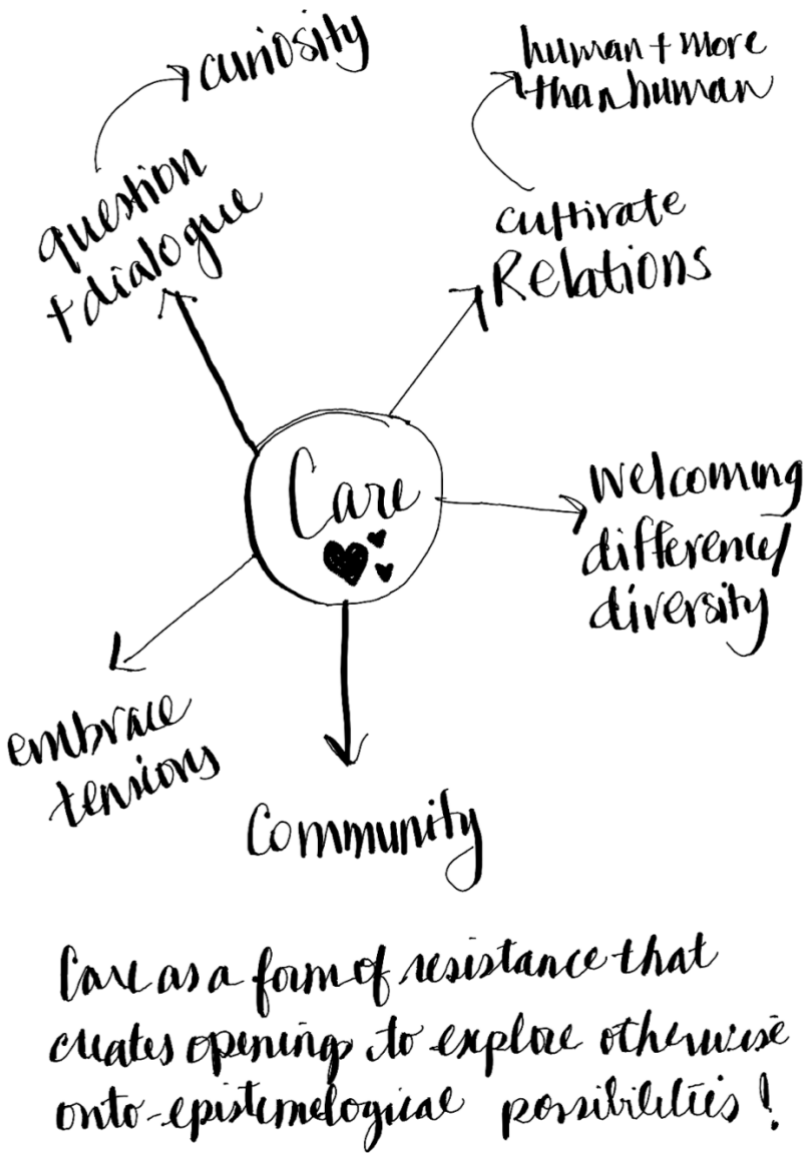
Appendix

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